religions, he perceived his love for himself (the King) in the fact that he tried so earnestly to induce him to accept this best of all paths to salvation'.

Quite apart from the many religious sects there were also, at Fatehpur Sikri, those who made up the many strands of Hindustani life in their teeming, provocative multitudes. There were, wrote the aghast Monserrate, 'worthless profligates, some of those who dress and adorn themselves like women' but when the Jesuits tried to convince Akbar to have them thrown out, he just laughed genially and walked away, limping slightly in his left leg, as was his habit, promising to think about what they had said. Monserrate admitted that Akbar was 'especially remarkable for his love of keeping great crowds of people around him and in his sight; and thus it comes about that his court is always thronged with multitudes of men of every type, though especially with the nobles, whom he commands to come from their province(s) and reside at court of a certain period each year. When he goes outside the palace, he is surrounded and followed by these nobles.' And it was not just the Christians that Akbar made himself available to—Monserrate also wrote about all those who prayed to meet him, both great and small, and that 'it is hard to exaggerate how accessible he makes himself to all who wish audience of him. For he creates an opportunity almost every day for any of the common people or of the nobles to see him and converse with him; and he endeavours to show himself pleasant-spoken and affable, rather than severe, towards all who come to speak with him. It is very remarkable how great an effect this courtesy and affability has in attaching to him the minds of his subjects.' Jahangir would also attest to this trait in his father, when he wrote his memoir many years later: 'He associated with the good of every race and creed and persuasion, and was gracious to all in accordance with their condition and understanding.'

If the Jesuits, the yogis, the Jains and the Parsees at Fatehpur Sikri had their more sedate garments, the nobility were all resplendent in their courtly clothes, for though the orthodox Muslim was constrained to wear clothes of 'wool, linen or cotton; and must be white', according to Monserrate, nonetheless '[Akbar] is so contemptuous of the instructions given by the false law-giver, that he wears garments of silk, beautifully embroidered in gold. His military cloak comes down only as far as the knee, according to the Christian fashion; and his boots cover his ankles completely.' 'The